Phanjoubam, had been ‘literally forced by the British on the Russians, weakened by a humiliating defeat at the hands of the Japanese’[21] in a war that ended in 1905. Russia had to promise to stay out of Tibet, but the rules of that Convention also applied to the British. Tibet, and also Afghanistan and Persia, were to remain neutral buffer zones between the Russian Empire and British India.[22]

Dutch scholar W.F. Van Eekelen opines that John Jordan, the British minister in Beijing, ‘was primarily concerned with the danger of Tibet gravitating towards Russia, but British freedom of manoeuvre was also limited by the Anglo-Russian Convention of 1907’.[23] Jordan recommended that Britain should not become party to any final treaty reached at Shimla, as that would involve the conclusion of a new agreement with Russia. He recommended McMahon, ‘to take an attitude of benevolent assistance and act as an honest broker’.[24]

The Russians had to be dealt with delicately. They were kept informed and the British went ahead with their plans to hold a conference at Shimla after the Russians had made it clear that they had no objection to it, and ‘a more formal communication to Russia would only be required if the well-recognised frontier were rectified’.[25]

The main point of contention during the nine months of negotiations was where the border between China and Tibet should be, as many ethnic Tibetans lived in areas outside of Lhasa’s political control. Technically, those areas were part of China, a country where central authorities at that time had difficulty controlling even less remote parts of the new republic. Perhaps influenced by the new arrangement for Mongolia, McMahon suggested that the Tibetan-inhabited areas should also be divided into ‘inner’ and ‘outer’ sections. Outer Tibet would be the part of Tibet traditionally under Lhasa’s control and remain a self-governing entity. Inner Tibet, an integral part of China, would serve as a buffer between Tibet ruled by Lhasa and Russian-dominated Outer Mongolia.[26] Outer Tibet would correspond roughly to the central and western parts of Tibet, whereas Inner Tibet, bordering on China, would consist of Amdo and part of Kham.[27]

After nine months of strenuous and sometimes heated deliberations, a convention was signed by the British and the Tibetans on 3 July 1914. It stipulated that ‘the Governments of Great Britain and China recognising